THE AZTECS

In the 15th century the Aztecs were the most powerful people in Mesoamerica, dominating over other city-states in a large area around their capital, Tenochtitlan. Their army, organized into legions 8,000 strong, was frequently on campaign, engaged in wars to extend the empire or suppress rebellion among the tributaries.

When no practical motive for warfare presented itself, the Aztecs arranged "flower wars". A tributary state was obliged to present its forces for battle at a specified time and place, to give the Aztecs practice in fighting and provide a fresh supply of prisoners. Taking prisoners was essential to Aztec life because it provided victims for human sacrifice. It also allowed an Aztec warrior to achieve promotion. His status depended on the number of enemy fighters he captured. Thus Aztec warriors struck at the legs of their opponents, seeking to disable them, rather than killing them with a blow to the head. The most successful warriors joined the elite orders of jaguar or eagle "knights". The Aztecs were not always victorious in pre-Columbian times. For example, in 1478 they lost a battle with the neighbouring Tarascans. But they were fierce, courageous fighters.

"PONDER THIS, EAGLE AND JAGUAR KNIGHTS, THOUGH ... CARVED IN JADE, YOU WILL BREAK."

FROM A POEM BY **KING NEZAHUALCOYOTL** OF TEXCOCO, 15TH CENTURY





Feathered shield and war club
Aztec warriors often carried round shields decorated with jaguar skin and feathers. Their wooden war clubs were edged with razor-sharp pieces of volcanic glass.

Aztec downfall
Cortez, the leader of the Spanish conquistadors, battles the Aztecs for the causeway to their island capital Tenochtitlan in 1520.